

UNIT 1: Introduction

1.1 Meaning of Research

Research is a word we use every day but in academics it has a specific meaning. Research means a careful, organized, and systematic process of finding answers to questions or solutions to problems. It is not just reading books or browsing the internet randomly. It follows a clear process and uses logical thinking to reach conclusions.

The word "research" comes from the French word *recherche* which means "to search again." This reflects the idea that research is not a one-time search but a repeated, careful investigation to make sure the findings are accurate and trustworthy.

In business, research helps managers understand their market, their customers, their employees, and their competition. Without research, decisions are based on guesswork. With research, decisions are based on facts and evidence.

Simple definition: Research is a systematic investigation that collects, analyzes, and interprets information to increase knowledge or solve a problem.

Why research matters in business:

- It reduces the risk of making wrong decisions
- It helps understand what customers want
- It shows what is working and what is not in a business
- It helps predict future trends

- It gives managers a factual basis for planning

Key characteristics of research:

- **Systematic:** Research follows a step by step plan. It does not jump randomly from one thing to another.
- **Objective:** Research is based on facts and data, not on personal feelings or opinions.
- **Empirical:** The conclusions come from real observations and measurements, not from imagination.
- **Logical:** Research uses reasoning to connect evidence to conclusions.
- **Replicable:** Another researcher should be able to repeat the same study and get similar results.
- **Cumulative:** Research builds on what earlier researchers have found. Each new study adds to the existing body of knowledge.
- **Critical:** Research questions existing assumptions and does not accept things at face value.

1.2 Scientific Research and Its Features

Scientific research is research that follows the scientific method. The scientific method is a structured way of investigating things that has been used in natural sciences for centuries. In recent decades, it has been applied to business and social problems as well.

Scientific research is different from everyday thinking because it is disciplined. When we face a problem in daily life, we often rely on intuition or past experience.

Scientific research does not rely on that alone. It requires evidence, testing, and logic.

Features of scientific research explained one by one:

- **Purposiveness:** Every scientific research study has a clear and defined purpose. There is always a specific question to answer or a problem to solve. Without a purpose, research has no direction.
- **Rigor:** Rigor means being careful, thorough, and precise. A rigorous study uses proper methods, collects quality data, and follows correct procedures. A study that cuts corners is not rigorous and cannot be trusted.
- **Testability:** The ideas and predictions made in scientific research must be testable. This means they can be checked against real data. If something cannot be tested, it is not a scientific claim.
- **Replicability:** If another researcher follows the same process in a different setting or time, they should get similar results. This is how science builds confidence in findings. A result that cannot be replicated is not reliable.
- **Precision and confidence:** Scientific research reports results with a degree of accuracy and certainty. Researchers do not say "this might work." They say "this works 95% of the time based on our study."
- **Objectivity:** Personal bias has no place in scientific research. The findings should reflect reality, not the researcher's opinions or wishes. Objectivity is maintained through proper methods and transparent reporting.
- **Generalizability:** Good scientific research produces findings that apply beyond just the specific sample studied. For example, a study on customer behavior in Kathmandu might generalize to urban consumers in Nepal.

- **Simplicity:** When two explanations both fit the data equally well, science prefers the simpler one. Simple explanations are easier to understand and test.

1.3 Types of Research

Research can be classified in several ways. The most important and fundamental classification in business research is the distinction between **basic research** and **applied research**.

Basic Research

Basic research is done to increase knowledge in general. It is not trying to solve any specific practical problem right now. The goal is to understand something better or to develop and test theories. It is sometimes called **pure research** or **fundamental research**.

For example, a researcher might study the general theory of why people make certain economic decisions. They are not trying to help a specific company sell more products. They are just trying to understand human decision making better.

Basic research is mostly done in universities, research institutions, and scientific labs. Its results may eventually have practical uses, but that is not the immediate goal.

Characteristics:

- Driven by curiosity and desire for knowledge
- Not focused on immediate application
- Produces theories, models, and concepts

- May take years to show practical value
- Conducted mostly in academic settings

Applied Research

Applied research is done to solve a specific, real world problem. A company, government, or organization identifies a problem and conducts research to find a solution. The results are meant to be used directly.

For example, a bank in Nepal notices that customer complaints have increased by 40% in the past year. It conducts research to find out why complaints are rising and what can be done. That is applied research.

Characteristics:

- Focused on solving a specific problem
- Results are used immediately in practice
- Time bound and goal oriented
- Common in business, healthcare, government, and engineering
- Builds on knowledge from basic research

Comparison table:

Basis	Basic Research	Applied Research
Main goal	Expand knowledge	Solve a specific problem
Focus	Theoretical	Practical
Setting	Academic or scientific	Business, industry, government
Output	Theories and models	Solutions and recommendations

Basis	Basic Research	Applied Research
Time frame	Often long term	Short to medium term
Example	Studying general consumer motivation	Studying why a specific company's sales fell

1.4 The Scientific Research Process

The scientific research process is a logical sequence of steps that guides a researcher from identifying a problem to reporting results. Each step builds on the previous one. Skipping a step or doing it poorly affects the quality of the whole study.

Here are the steps explained in plain language:

Step 1: Identify and define the research problem

This is the most important step. If you do not know exactly what you are trying to find out, your research will have no direction. The problem should be stated clearly and specifically. A vague problem leads to vague research.

For example, "Why is XYZ Company losing customers?" is better than just "customer issues."

Step 2: Review existing literature

Before starting your own research, find out what others have already studied on the same or similar topic. This is called a literature review. It helps you avoid

repeating what has already been done, understand the background of your topic, and identify gaps that your research can fill.

Step 3: Formulate a hypothesis

Based on the literature review and your understanding of the problem, make a prediction about what you expect to find. This prediction is called a hypothesis. It is a tentative answer to your research question that you will test with data.

Step 4: Design the research

Decide how you will conduct the study. This includes choosing the type of research, deciding who to collect data from, how many people to include, what tool to use (questionnaire, interview, etc.), and how to analyze the data.

Step 5: Collect data

Gather information from your chosen sources using the method you decided in the design step. This could be conducting surveys, doing interviews, observing behavior, or collecting secondary data.

Step 6: Analyze the data

Process the data you collected. Use appropriate statistical tools for quantitative data. Use coding and thematic analysis for qualitative data. Look for patterns and relationships.

Step 7: Interpret the findings

Make sense of what the analysis tells you. Do the results support your hypothesis? What do the findings mean for the research problem? Are there any surprising results?

Step 8: Report and communicate

Write up the research in a formal report. Share the findings with the relevant audience. This could be a thesis, a journal article, a business report, or a presentation.

The process is often not perfectly linear. Researchers sometimes go back to earlier steps based on what they find. For example, analyzing data might reveal that the original hypothesis needs to be modified.

1.5 Paradigm Shifts: Positivism vs Interpretivism

A paradigm is a way of looking at the world. In research, a paradigm includes assumptions about what reality is, what counts as knowledge, and how knowledge should be gathered. Two major paradigms dominate social and business research.

What is Positivism?

Positivism is the belief that the world exists independently of our perception of it. Reality is out there, it is fixed, and it can be measured objectively. Positivism treats the social world like the natural world. Just as we can measure temperature or weight, positivists believe we can measure human behavior and social phenomena.

Positivist research uses quantitative methods. It collects numbers, runs statistical tests, and looks for patterns and laws that explain behavior. The researcher is supposed to be neutral and detached from what is being studied.

Key features of positivism:

- Reality is objective and external to people
- Knowledge comes through observation and measurement
- Uses quantitative, scientific methods
- Researcher stays separate from the subject of research
- Aims to find general laws and patterns
- Results can be generalized
- Focuses on facts, not meanings or feelings

Example of positivist research: A researcher surveys 500 employees using a questionnaire and uses statistical analysis to find that job satisfaction scores are positively correlated with salary levels. The conclusion is based on numbers and statistical evidence.

What is Interpretivism?

Interpretivism challenges the positivist view. Interpretivists argue that human beings are not like physical objects. People think, feel, and give meaning to their actions. You cannot understand human behavior the same way you measure temperature.

To truly understand why people do what they do, you must understand the meaning behind their actions. This requires talking to people, listening to their

stories, and observing them in their natural environment. Interpretivist research uses qualitative methods.

Key features of interpretivism:

- Reality is subjective and constructed by people through their experiences and interactions
- Knowledge comes from understanding meaning and context
- Uses qualitative methods like interviews and observation
- Researcher is part of the research process and interacts with participants
- Findings are context specific and not easily generalized
- Focuses on depth, not breadth

Example of interpretivist research: A researcher conducts in depth interviews with 20 employees to understand why they feel demotivated despite receiving good salaries. The findings reveal complex emotional and social factors that numbers alone could not capture.

Comparison:

Dimension	Positivism	Interpretivism
View of reality	Objective and fixed	Subjective and constructed
Research method	Quantitative	Qualitative
Goal	Explain and predict	Understand and interpret
Researcher role	Detached and neutral	Involved and reflective
Type of data	Numbers and statistics	Words, stories, observations
Generalizability	High	Low, context specific

Dimension	Positivism	Interpretivism
Example	Survey with statistical analysis	In depth interview study

Modern business researchers often combine both approaches in what is called a **mixed methods** study. This gives a more complete picture of the research problem.

1.6 Management Research

Concept of Management Research

Management research is the systematic study of business and organizational problems using research methods. It applies the tools and techniques of research to understand and improve management practice.

Management research is interdisciplinary. It draws from economics, psychology, sociology, mathematics, and organizational theory. It deals with topics like leadership, motivation, strategy, marketing, finance, human resources, consumer behavior, and organizational performance.

The key thing about management research is that it is not just about theory. It is also about practical impact. A good management research study should ultimately help managers make better decisions or help organizations improve.

Nature of Management Research

- **Interdisciplinary:** It borrows ideas, theories, and methods from many different academic fields.

- **Problem oriented:** It almost always starts with a real problem or question faced by managers or organizations.
- **Applied focus:** The goal is usually to produce knowledge that is useful in practice.
- **Dynamic:** Business environments change constantly, so management research must adapt to new realities.
- **Ethical:** Research involving people and organizations must follow ethical guidelines to protect participants and maintain honesty.
- **Empirical:** Claims must be supported by data, not just logic or opinion.

Value of Management Research in Business Decision Making

Good research makes better managers. Here is why management research is valuable:

- **Reduces uncertainty:** Business decisions are made under uncertainty. Research provides facts that reduce that uncertainty and increase confidence in decisions.
- **Identifies problems early:** Research can detect issues like declining customer satisfaction or rising employee turnover before they become crises.
- **Finds opportunities:** Market research can reveal unmet customer needs or emerging market segments that a company can target.
- **Tests ideas before implementation:** A company can test a new pricing strategy or product concept through research before spending money on full implementation.
- **Improves efficiency:** Research can identify bottlenecks and inefficiencies in operations and suggest improvements.

- **Validates strategies:** After implementing a strategy, research can track whether it is working and whether adjustments are needed.
- **Builds competitive advantage:** Companies that understand their market better than competitors through research have a strategic edge.

1.7 Applying Scientific Thinking to Business Problems

Scientific thinking means approaching any problem with curiosity, logic, evidence, and skepticism. In everyday business, managers often rely on intuition or experience. Scientific thinking challenges this by demanding evidence.

Here is how scientific thinking is applied in business:

1. Define the problem precisely

Do not jump to solutions before clearly understanding the problem. Ask: what exactly is happening? When did it start? Who is affected? How often does it occur? A clearly defined problem is halfway solved.

2. Gather relevant information

Collect data about the problem. Look at past records, talk to people involved, observe the situation. Do not rely only on what you think you know.

3. Develop alternative explanations

Think of multiple possible reasons for the problem. Do not assume the first explanation that comes to mind is correct. Generate several hypotheses.

4. Test each explanation against evidence

Look at the data you collected. Which explanation best fits the evidence? Are there facts that contradict some explanations? Eliminate explanations that do not fit the evidence.

5. Choose the best solution

Based on the evidence, select the most likely explanation and the most appropriate solution.

6. Implement and monitor

Put the solution into action and track the results. Collect more data after implementation to see if the problem has been solved.

7. Adjust based on new evidence

If the results are not as expected, go back and revise your understanding. Scientific thinking is a continuous cycle, not a one time event.

This approach helps managers avoid common thinking errors like:

- Jumping to conclusions without evidence
- Relying too heavily on one person's opinion
- Ignoring evidence that contradicts what they believe
- Confusing correlation with causation

1.8 Ethical Issues in Business Research

Ethics in research means doing research in a way that is honest, fair, and respectful of the people involved. Business research often involves collecting sensitive

information from employees, customers, or competitors. This creates ethical responsibilities.

If ethical standards are not followed, research can harm people, mislead the public, or be used inappropriately. Ethical research builds trust and ensures findings are credible.

Key Ethical Principles

Informed Consent

Before a person participates in research, they must be told what the research is about, what they will be asked to do, how their information will be used, and who will have access to it. Participation must be completely voluntary. No one should be forced or pressured to take part.

Informed consent is usually collected through a consent form that participants sign before the study begins.

Confidentiality

Any information shared by participants must be kept private. It should only be used for the research purpose stated and should not be shared with unauthorized people. If a company shares its internal data with a researcher, that data must not be disclosed to competitors or the public.

Anonymity

Anonymity means that the identity of participants is not revealed in the research report. Even if the researcher knows who said what, the report should present data

in a way that does not identify individuals. This encourages honest and open responses.

Right to Withdraw

Participants must be free to stop participating at any point without facing any negative consequences. A participant can change their mind after signing the consent form, and the researcher must respect that.

Protection from Harm

Research should not cause any harm to participants. This includes:

- Physical harm (unlikely in business research but possible in some experiments)
- Psychological harm (stress or anxiety caused by sensitive questions)
- Social harm (damage to reputation or relationships)
- Financial harm (loss of employment or business due to disclosed information)

Honesty and Integrity

Researchers must be truthful at every stage. This means:

- Do not fabricate or make up data
- Do not manipulate or selectively report data to support a preferred conclusion
- Report findings accurately even if they contradict your hypothesis
- Acknowledge limitations and sources of error honestly

Avoiding Plagiarism

Plagiarism means using someone else's ideas, words, or work without giving them credit. It is a serious ethical and academic violation. All sources used in research must be properly cited. This includes not only direct quotes but also paraphrased ideas.

Conflict of Interest

A researcher must disclose any personal, financial, or professional interest that might bias the research. For example, if a researcher is paid by a company to evaluate their product, that relationship should be disclosed.

Data Privacy

With the rise of digital data, privacy has become increasingly important. Personal data collected during research must be stored securely and disposed of properly after the research is complete.